

DTF Cheat Sheet: Heat Press

● SUB CAMP 2026 · NINJA TRANSFERS

Tape this next to your heat press. Same press, new fabric.

Settings by fabric

Preheat first. Pressing pillow under seams or multi-layer goods. Silicone cover = silicone upper platen pad (runs hotter than parchment or teflon).

FABRIC	NO SILICONE COVER	WITH SILICONE COVER
Cotton (light or dark)	310°F · 15s · Med-High	330°F · 15s · Med-High
50/50 blends, triblends	300°F · 12s · Med	320°F · 12s · Med
Polyester, jerseys, mesh	290°F · 12s · Med + pillow	310°F · 12s · Med + pillow
Denim, canvas, heavy	320°F · 15s · Firm	340°F · 15s · Firm
Hoodies (multi-layer)	310°F · 17s · Med-High + pillow	330°F · 17s · Med-High + pillow
Hats / structured	320°F top · 130°F bot · 15s + tape	340°F top · 130°F bot · 15s + tape

Steps

1. (Optional) Pre-press the shirt 3 to 5 seconds to pull moisture out. Helpful on humid days.
2. Lay the garment flat on the press.
3. Place the DTF film design-side up on the garment.
4. Cover with parchment, teflon sheet, or silicone protector.
5. Press using the temp, time, and pressure for your fabric (table above).

The Peel

Wait at least 5 seconds after the press lifts, then peel the film in one smooth motion. Hot peel is fine. The transfer should still be warm.

If any part of the design lifts with the film, lay it back down, give that area a quick second press, then re-peel.

COLD PEEL ONLY

Glitter, gold or silver foil, and glow-in-the-dark are cold peel. Wait until fully cool before peeling those.

The Second Press

DON'T SKIP THIS

The step most crafters skip is the one that matters most for wash durability.

After peeling, cover the design with fresh parchment (or a single layer of T-shirt material) and press again at the **same temp, time, and pressure as your first press**. Improves hand feel, reduces shine, locks in long-term wash performance. Wait 24 hours before the first wash.

When Something Goes Wrong

ISSUE	FIX (NINJA TRANSFERS)
Transfer not adhering properly	Lay it back down and press again with added pressure and heat (+15°F). If that doesn't work, increase temperature by increments of 15°F until it transfers correctly.
Transfer shifting during application	Use Thermal Heat Tape to secure the transfer. Close the press gently to avoid air movement. Pre-press the garment to create a flat surface.
Design cracking or peeling after washing	Always turn garments inside-out before washing. Wash in cold water on gentle cycle. Avoid bleach and harsh detergents. Air dry or tumble dry on low heat.
Skipping the second press	Cover your exposed design with a protective guard sheet and press for about 10 to 15 seconds using the same temperature and pressure settings.

What You Can Press Next

Same press, different transfer. Once you nail cotton, none of these are scary.

Hoodies

Fleece

Denim

Tote bags

Hats

Dark cotton

Heavy cotton

Glow

Foil

Glitter

Spangle

UV DTF on hard goods